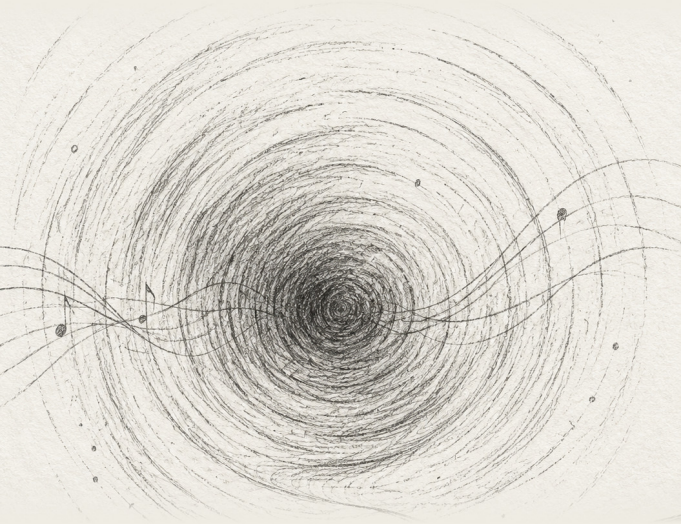
WHILE THE ECHO LASTS

A LIFE IN MUSIC



EVGENIY TYURKIN · LUNA

THE ETERNAL CYCLE · AUTHOR'S EDITION
KRASNOYARSK · 1979

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While the Echo Lasts

A memoir of a life in music

Third literary edition · October 2026

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An autobiographical literary manuscript based on Evgeniy Tyurkin’s recollections.

Part One. Hearing the Whole

The Orchestra That Wasn't There

If I try to remember when I first understood the difference between music and a collection of sounds, the memory isn't of a successful performance. Quite the opposite. It's one of the most miserable scenes of my childhood, a scene that contained every outward sign of a concert except the one thing a concert actually needs.

Our music school took its orchestra to perform in a small

town near Krasnoyarsk. The town's name has disappeared from my memory, but I remember the feeling of that trip, and I remember our conductor's surname: Perfiliev. My father knew him and didn't think much of him. At the time, I couldn't really understand what one adult musician might have against another. To me, it seemed simple: there is an orchestra, there is a program, and the program has to be learned and played.

I played trombone. My father, a professional trombonist, helped me prepare at home. In our house, preparation never meant, “Well, that sounds more or less all right.” If the score called for a

particular note, it had to be played at the right moment, with the right attack, length, and volume. Fingers, breath, hearing, and memory had to work together. If something didn't come out right, we repeated it. Sometimes many times. There is nothing particularly romantic about that, especially when you're a child and instead of going outside you have to tackle the same difficult passage yet again. But I knew my music. As far as I could tell, I had done my part.

We arrived. The concert began. I raised my instrument, came in where I was supposed to, and almost immediately heard

something impossible. The music around me was falling apart.

Everyone may well have had sheet music in front of them. Probably everyone was honestly trying to play what was written. Only one child came in early, another late, a third played the wrong pitch, a fourth drifted away from the tempo. Some sounds happened to meet, which only made it worse: for an instant it seemed that the orchestra was coming together, and a moment later it scattered again. There was a conductor. There were instruments. There were enough players. There was no orchestra.

I knew what the next phrase was supposed to sound like and could

hear several incompatible versions of it at once. It's hard to explain this to someone who hears music as a single stream. Imagine reading a familiar sentence while everyone around you pronounces a different word from it, each at their own speed. Now and then a nearly meaningful sequence appears, then disintegrates. Meanwhile you must keep reading correctly, without being dragged away by the chorus. That's roughly how it felt.

I was ashamed. Not merely irritated or disappointed: ashamed. I was onstage with the others. The audience had no obligation to work out which

children had prepared properly and which hadn't. They heard an orchestra giving a performance, and that collective sound belonged to everyone under the same banner. At that moment I felt with particular force how helpless an individual performer can be. You can know your own part perfectly, but you cannot repair an entire ensemble on your neighbors' behalf.

I don't know what the audience thought. I don't know whether the other musicians noticed what was happening, or felt as bad about it as I did. What stayed with me was the sense that, for some reason, nobody else seemed to care much. Perhaps that was

an unfair impression formed by a child, but the feeling itself was real. I had never felt worse on a stage.

Since then I've been suspicious of the words “Everyone did their job.” They tell you nothing about the result. You can assemble a group of diligent specialists and end up with a completely unworkable whole. In music, you hear that without any explanation. No instrument exists separately from the others, even when it's playing a solo. What it means depends on what happens around it.

It took me years to put that thought into words. Back then the orchestra that wasn't there

expressed it for me, so convincingly that the lesson stayed for life.

The funny thing is that as an adult I learned to enjoy the exact opposite exercise. In Toronto, at symphony concerts, I sometimes close my eyes and fish one instrument out of the orchestral sound. A bassoon, perhaps, or a phrase somewhere in the woodwinds. First I isolate it by ear; then I open my eyes and try to find the person who is playing it. A little game: find the separate line without losing the whole. A very peaceful pastime compared with that childhood concert.

I suppose that's how I listen to music: sometimes as a whole and

sometimes as individual voices. A slight change in attention and the bass comes forward, then the flute, then the rhythm, then the way two instruments answer each other. The piece remains the same. Only the point from which I look at it changes.

Years later, when Valka and I began playing long improvisations, that ability proved much more useful than fast fingers. And when we eventually learned to find our way out of unexpected turns together, the lesson from that disastrous school concert acquired a sequel. I simply didn't know it yet.

A Four for Swing

I was both lucky and unlucky: my father was a musician. A professional trombonist. On the one hand, music was always present at home, and talk about instruments and performance was part of ordinary life. On the other, my father did not treat a child's practice as harmless entertainment. If you were going to play, you were going to play properly.

I started learning guitar very young, around six. Trombone came with music school. There were the familiar subjects: solfège, music history and appreciation, lessons on the

instrument, rehearsals. Solfège soon grew a little boring. I regarded musical dictation as an understandable task: the teacher plays, you listen, you write down what you hear. It was much more interesting to discover how music works and why different instruments affect you differently.

One of my favorite works in music-appreciation class was Prokofiev's *Peter and the Wolf*. It's wonderfully constructed. You don't need to lecture a child about why each character has its own voice; you can simply let the music speak. Here is one timbre, here is another part, and here they meet. Music tells a story

without having to spell it out at every step. I still like returning to that arrangement: separate lines that come together to make an event.

My father knew jazz very well. I'd heard it from early childhood, from about the age of five. Swing wasn't some mysterious term from a textbook. I was used to the way a melody can lean back from the beat, how apparent unevenness can produce a remarkably precise inner motion. In jazz you can place everything in its formally correct position and still destroy the music if that pulse disappears.

But lessons with my father were difficult. His demands weren't

always understandable to a child. You thought you'd played the right note, only to discover that you'd started it the wrong way. You thought you'd held it for the right length, but apparently you hadn't shaped the sound correctly. Working on phrasing could be especially painful: he could hear things I couldn't yet hear or reproduce. So there were repetitions, irritation, sometimes tears. Today I understand how much I learned. At the time I mostly wanted the difficult bit finally to come out right.

For my graduation exam at music school I played the jazz standard *Ja-Da*. For a student it was quite a demanding piece, provided you

treated it as more than a mechanical series of notes. Everything mattered: swing, attack, accents, dynamics. I particularly liked controlling the volume within a single sustained note. It might begin barely audible, grow, fill out, and then disappear again. The pitch remains the same, yet an entire little story unfolds inside it.

That sounds odd in ordinary conversation: how can so much happen inside one note? Easily. You have to control breathing, your embouchure, pressure, the speed at which the sound changes. You're not pressing a button that starts a sound and then lets it continue by itself. You

lead the sound. Play the whole piece at one volume and the correct pitches and durations may remain, but half the meaning disappears.

The trouble was the accompaniment. The pianist assigned to play with me had been trained in the classical tradition. She knew the notes and played neatly, but couldn't find the jazz feel the piece needed. This isn't a criticism of classical training: it's simply a different musical language. Everything came out too straight. The swing straightened with it, and I found it physically uncomfortable to play over her accompaniment.

In the end my father sat down at the piano himself. He was a trombonist, not a pianist; a complex accompaniment at the keyboard was much harder for him than for my teacher. During the exam he made mistakes, landed on the wrong chords, sometimes put his fingers on entirely the wrong keys. But he kept the rhythm right. And suddenly I was able to play the piece as I felt it.

This isn't a story about a bad pianist getting in the way of a good student. Quite the contrary: everyone was trying, only their musical experiences were different. Still, I heard very clearly that correct chords and

correct music aren't always the same thing. My father missed the details while preserving the piece's character. He gave me something to stand on.

I got a four out of five. A fair grade, as I thought even then. I still remember that exam fondly, despite all the nerves that preceded it. Many years later I found a video of a trombonist demonstrating the piece as a teaching example. Suddenly I recognized the nuances my father had taught me. The same shape, the same sense of phrasing. It felt very warm to realize that all those lessons had left a lasting trace.

In a way, my father taught me two opposing things. The first was to respect precision. The second was not to confuse precision with mechanical obedience to rules. You can play evenly and miss the music itself. Or you can get an individual chord wrong while holding on to the thing everyone came together to play.

Later, when I switched to bass, that knowledge changed what the word *rhythm* meant to me. A bassist doesn't simply keep count. He creates the reference point against which everyone else can move more freely, sometimes a little ahead, sometimes a little behind. If that reference point

falls apart, even beautifully learned parts can turn into the orchestra from my childhood.

Music That Doesn't Explain Itself

Before I learned to explain my musical tastes, there were records. The Latvian band Zodiac made an especially strong impression, with their synthesizer-driven, cosmic sound. I was about five. I could spend ages studying the covers, with their fantastic spaces and figures and hints of future worlds, while listening to music that seemed to fit the images perfectly. The music felt real, although it described nothing in words.

The bass playing was magnificent. A child who doesn't yet think about orchestration rarely singles the bass out for attention. But I listened and felt how the low line supported an enormous structure: synthesizers could fly wherever they pleased as long as that foundation remained beneath them. Later, when I became a bassist myself, the memory of Zodiac returned as a practical challenge: how do you give music a sense of space when you have only a handful of instruments?

For a long time, words in songs actually got in my way. It wasn't that I disliked singing. I regarded the voice as a fully fledged

instrument: tone, pitch, attack, breathing, freedom of intonation. You can listen to a good singer deliver a single phrase again and again just for the way they shape the sound. But lyrics seemed like unnecessary hints. Music created its own images in my head, and then someone came along to tell me which story I was supposed to imagine. I wanted to remain free to interpret what I heard.

There were exceptions, of course. I loved Vysotsky, and there were other songs with good lyrics that I enjoyed. My priorities were simply different: music first. Even with rock songs I often mentally separated the instrumental lines and placed the vocals alongside

guitar, bass, and drums. One part among the others.

And yet one of my strongest childhood experiments with music involved precisely those words. Entirely by accident, the tune of the children's Christmas song *A Little Fir Tree Was Born in the Forest* began playing in my head, and the lyrics of the solemn wartime anthem *The Sacred War* attached themselves to it. I hadn't been trying to fit them together. Two familiar things simply collided and revealed a surprising rhythmic kinship. The result was so absurd that I laughed. Then I felt uncomfortable: *The Sacred War* belonged to a genuine historical

tragedy, and singing its words to a cheerful children's holiday tune seemed almost unthinkable.

So I reversed the experiment. I kept the story of the little fir tree but gave it, in my imagination, the heavy, tragic melody. I was stunned by how radically the meaning of the familiar tale changed. A tree grows in the forest. The blizzard sings it to sleep; the frost wraps it in snow; it lives in its own world. Then a man comes and chops it down at the roots. For the children, a celebration begins. For the tree, life ends. Before long the needles will start to fall, the tree will be carried outside into the snow, and nobody will need it anymore.

Everyone knows this story. There is no surprise ending. Yet change the music, and the protagonist changes with it. Before, you stood with the children enjoying a beautiful celebration. Now, somehow, you find yourself beside a tree nobody ever asked whether it wanted to decorate someone else's home. The children's joy doesn't vanish; the tree's tragedy appears alongside it. Both stories fit the same set of events.

I was embarrassed even to tell people about that joke. But it stayed with me for life. As an adult I realized it was a simple and fairly accurate observation: music does more than

accompany an event. It directs the listener's sympathy. Depending on the sound, the same action can be perceived as victory, loss, threat, or comedy.

Much later, I changed my mind about words themselves. Good poetry, it turns out, doesn't have to explain the music at all. It offers another independent layer of images, one you can explore or leave in the background. I used to fear that lyrics would take freedom away. Then I discovered that they could expand it. The listener decides where to dive deeper: into timbre, harmony, rhythm, the meaning of the lines, or the connections between all of them.

As a teenager I certainly wasn't thinking in those terms. At the time, something else mattered much more: finding people I could play with, outside the textbook. And in Krasnoyarsk I found them.

Part Two. Itsari

Sixteen, at Someone Else's Concert

I went to another rock concert at about the age when musical tastes seem to define everything: the way you dress, the people you talk to, the attitude you take toward the world. I liked punk. Sex Pistols, Green Day, The Offspring. Rock music had this remarkable ability to gather people who apparently owed each other nothing, yet knew exactly why they were there. At least while the music was playing.

Krasnoyarsk had a scene of its own. Plenty of heavy metal, plenty of punk, plenty of songs in the spirit of the Russian rock underground. I went to listen and watch: how people stood onstage, which gestures seemed to come naturally, how an audience reacted. Eventually you come for more than your favorite songs. You start watching the process itself. Why can one musician command the room while apparently doing nothing remarkable, while another can't win its attention even with virtuoso technique?

One such concert marked the beginning of my history with people who would remain part of

my life for years. The band was called **Itsari**. By then it had already existed for about two years. Mitka, Valka, and Vitaly, whom everyone called Faust, had started it. Their early music had something of Grazhdanskaya Oborona, Bashlachev, and the Russian underground rock tradition: songs where direct expression, energy, and vocal character matter. Over time they began trying other things. But that evening I knew neither their history nor how far ours would go.

I went to that concert in 1996 simply to hear music. I wasn't auditioning, trying to meet musicians, or looking for a band.

I had no plan to become a bassist. I was fairly confident on acoustic guitar, but bass was another matter. I'd tried it now and then, yet wouldn't have called myself a bass player.

First a man named Lyonya came over. He asked whether I wanted to join the others. I immediately warned him that I couldn't really play bass. Surely that should have ended the conversation. Why invite a person who has just admitted he doesn't know the instrument you need?

Then Mitka came over and made the same suggestion.

I repeated myself: what sort of bassist would I be? He replied quite calmly:

“Come along. We'll play.”

No grand promises, no demand that I first become a proper musician. Just come and see what happens. So I came. That's how my four years with Itsari began.

Lyonya died a long time ago. Sometimes I think how strangely these turning points work. Someone walks up to you at a rock concert and says a few ordinary words. Years later, when you try to reconstruct your own musical history, you realize how differently it might have

turned out if that conversation hadn't happened.

The day before, I'd been watching the stage from the audience, listening to other people's music. Now I was going to rehearsals myself. I was no longer judging someone else's performance. I had to find my own place in the shared sound.

That's more frightening than it seems. Sitting in the audience, you can have any opinion you like. That solo is too simple. The singer missed a note there. That guitar effect was a strange choice. At a rehearsal, opinions immediately become a responsibility to offer something yourself. It needn't be the best

idea, but it ought to be yours, and preferably at the right moment. It's easy to get lost inside someone else's song: its shape is already familiar to everyone else, while you're trying to work out where you belong.

Guitar was easier for me. By then I knew the acoustic instrument well. Bass demanded a different way of thinking. Yes, I had played it in a school ensemble and taken part in a few rather unsuccessful recording experiments. None of that gave me confidence. You can't simply think of a bass as a guitar with fewer strings and a lower tuning. From the outside it looks as though the bassist plays a few simple notes. When you start

playing, you discover how much depends on precisely those “simple notes.”

Things became interesting when I stopped treating the bass part as a narrow corridor someone else had assigned me. A song already had chords, a melody, lyrics. But between those elements lay an enormous amount of space. You could accent an unexpected beat, shift the harmony with one passing note, propose a rhythm that ran counter to the guitar instead of merely doubling it. You just had to learn how not to get in everyone else's way.

Mitka was the group's official leader, though not because he issued orders and told everyone

their place. He was the man who could talk to almost anybody. Expressive, easy with people, with a kind of looseness onstage that reminded me of Jim Morrison. His songs tended to be relatively simple: two or three chords, a clear foundation, and the rest of us built around it. That simplicity sometimes made a song more powerful. If a piece isn't crowded with decisions already made in advance, each musician can give it a character of their own.

Valka, by contrast, often seemed to disappear into his guitar. He could play with his back to the audience, barely concerned with putting on a show. Vitaly had his

own way of hearing: not always precise in vocal pitch, but exceptionally alert to the right moment to enter, to color, to unexpected combinations of sound. Later Kirill would add flute, harmonica, and effects through a microphone. Each of them brought his own hearing and personality to the group.

Among rock musicians, virtuosity was often treated almost as an athletic achievement. Faster, higher, more difficult. You could play a solo behind your back, dazzle the audience with the speed of your hands. That could be impressive. But I became more interested in what happened *between* the musicians while one

of them was demonstrating his skill. Were the others listening to him? Was he listening to them? Or were they all politely waiting for the obligatory display to end?

I didn't have an answer yet. Itsari was where I began looking. At the time it didn't resemble a philosophical investigation. It looked like ordinary rehearsals with young people who wanted to play. Over the years I realized that this is as real an education as any other. There is no diploma, but the consequences of every mistake can be heard.

No Pick

Giving up the pick was my first almost-engineering decision on bass. It seemed funny at first. A pick is a tiny piece of plastic. Musicians everywhere carry them in their pockets, lose them, buy more. Why worry about it? But I noticed that I became accustomed to a particular thickness, edge, and stiffness. Pick up a different one and suddenly your fingers are unhappy. Enough already depends on the instrument, the room, and your own condition. Why add another dependency voluntarily?

I could have bought a bag of identical picks. Then another bag as backup. I could have given my friends a couple each, so the right kind would always be available in an emergency. But that felt like complicating life for something I might not need at all. I tried playing with my fingers and soon realized I didn't want to go back.

Fingerstyle playing opened a different surface of the instrument. It's not just the sound. You're closer to the string; you actually feel it resist your finger, begin to vibrate, behave differently depending on how much force you use. You can play softly or sharply, pluck and immediately mute. The hand

stops being merely a holder for the thing that makes notes; it becomes part of the sound-producing mechanism itself.

Later I learned slap bass. It gave the instrument another possibility: not merely to carry the low line, but to establish rhythm with percussive strokes. Then came tapping: producing a note by striking the string directly against the fingerboard. Later, two-handed tapping, with left and right hands doing different jobs. Then chords, intervals, arpeggios. Things usually divided among bass, guitar, and even some of the drums gradually became possible

on one instrument, within its limitations.

The funny part is that I never set out to amaze anyone with elaborate technique. I needed to play a particular musical idea and my usual set of methods wasn't enough. If you want a low foundation and a higher interval at the same time, you look for a way to produce both. If you want a rhythmic pattern to appear in a gap, you try muting the strings and turning fingertip taps into percussion. Technique follows the problem, not the other way around.

I gradually discovered that you can play chords on a bass, not just isolated notes. They aren't always

as full as guitar chords: dense harmony down low turns muddy very quickly. You have to choose intervals carefully, spread them across registers, feel where the harmony stays clear. The fifth string would come later, on the bass Petrov built for me, but the need for a deeper and broader sound had already appeared.

Another skill proved unexpectedly useful: making the sound quieter. Not merely turning down the amplifier, but changing the attack itself. You can tap a string hard and make it ring. Or you can touch it very gently while muting part of the string. The clear pitch nearly disappears, leaving a short,

drum-like sound with the faintest harmonic tint. Sometimes that serves the music better than a full chord.

And here the trombone returned, along with everything my father had taught me. One note can swell, retreat, change character. Bass works differently, but the question is the same: what can happen *inside* the time occupied by a sound? How do you make it move when there aren't many notes? How do you let the listener feel tension changing before they even recognize a new harmony?

I paid less and less attention to how many notes I played and more to the work each note was doing. A bass part can be short

and exact. It can become a solo. It can hold the pulse while everything else dissolves into echoes. Sometimes the best part is a single note that doesn't need to be abandoned too soon.

Much later, when I took up archery, I recognized the same habit in myself. There, too, it made sense to remove unnecessary equipment and not become dependent on a particular glove or some other tiny accessory without which shooting suddenly seemed impossible. But music was where I first felt that principle in action. Remove unnecessary dependencies, and you have more freedom left to listen.

Eventually the freedom to listen interested me far more than the ability to play fast.

Valka's Wrong Note

Some lessons arrive as rules: do this, or you'll make a mistake. Others aren't lessons anyone intended to teach. You simply happen to be present when another person does something unexpected, and realize you will never hear music quite the same way again.

We were rehearsing something. I think it was one of our free improvisations; I don't remember the exact date. Valka was playing guitar, I was listening and

answering on bass. Suddenly he landed on a note that plainly didn't agree with the harmony emerging around it. A harsh interval appeared, a minor or major second. Two neighboring pitches hung in the air at once, and your ear demanded that somebody put an end to the torture immediately.

I expected Valka to correct himself. He couldn't possibly have missed what had happened. But instead he held the note. Held it and held it, as though he wanted to show how foreign it was. And by doing so he made it stop sounding like a slip. It was as if he were proposing a new tension, letting it grow until the

return to familiar harmony would become an event in its own right.

And then he returned. The note gradually resolved; everything fell into place. The crucial thing was that it wasn't quite the same place anymore. After that dissonance, the familiar foundation felt different. As though you'd stepped outside a room, seen it from another angle, and only then come back in.

I remembered that for life. It doesn't mean all mistakes suddenly became good mistakes. Sometimes a slip is just a slip; sometimes it wrecks a phrase or gets in your partner's way. But I discovered that you don't always

have to flee an unpleasant sound at once. You can try to understand it. And if another musician is attentive enough, they can adapt, play around the surprise, and help it become meaningful.

That's the enormous difference between a competition in technique and making music together. In a competition, who made the mistake matters. In an improvisation, what the group does with what just happened matters more. One person plays a wrong or simply strange note; now everyone else has a choice. Pretend it didn't happen. Stop. Or answer in a way that turns it into the beginning of something new.

Little by little I understood that the last possibility was what I wanted to learn. Knowing your instrument isn't enough. You have to hear another person's intention, not only what they've already played but what they're still forming. Valka hangs back on a phrase; I can leave him space. He starts climbing into a higher melodic line; I hold the low foundation. I turn a melody into rhythm; he steps out of the background and takes the lead. All without words, though of course we talked and discussed things at rehearsals.

That's why I never liked bringing a partner a composition worked out down to the final note. If I

decide everything he is supposed to play, he becomes a performer executing *my* idea. I wanted to hear what would grow out of our shared work. Sometimes it's enough to offer a rhythmic figure, a hint of harmony, or one melody. Then you must leave room for an answer.

Later I began calling this a feedback loop. It sounds technical, but in music it's very physical. Sound reaches another musician's ear, changes his next movement; that movement comes back to me and changes mine. There is no finished piece sitting between us that we're carefully reproducing. The piece emerges within the chain of responses.

When that process works, you can play for a very long time. Not because nobody knows how to finish, but because every new phrase opens another possibility. Sometimes an idea runs out quickly. Then it's better to stop. Sometimes it doesn't run out for twenty minutes. Why cut it short merely because an ordinary song is supposed to last three?

And here the childhood orchestra comes back into view. There, everyone had an assigned part, yet no whole appeared. With Valka, the opposite could happen: we had no agreed parts at all, and a whole emerged almost immediately. So it doesn't live in the sheet music, or in the

technique of any one player. It happens between people.

The City That Played Along

Even now, when I think about those years, it's difficult to separate the music from Krasnoyarsk itself. In my memory, the band never exists apart from streets and apartments, the corridors we walked through carrying instruments, the makeshift food we bought by pooling our money. These were years when our principal resource was time. Nobody specifically gave it to us. It was simply there. We studied, some of us were beginning to work, but life hadn't yet

fragmented into obligations so thoroughly that even meeting a friend required arranging it days in advance.

After rehearsals we could go for a walk. Sometimes that was because rehearsal had gone nowhere. Everyone arrived, tuned up, started playing, but nothing happened. Notes were there, desire was there, and music wasn't. In a sense it resembled the school orchestra, except that now nobody felt obliged to pretend a concert had to happen. We could admit that tonight it wasn't working and go outside. The music stayed with us; we just weren't holding instruments anymore.

Krasnoyarsk offered plenty of accidental discoveries: a large city with the Yenisei River, bridges, and strange acoustic spaces. In one place traffic hums evenly above your head; in another the same sound returns from several directions. You don't necessarily notice these things when you're hurrying somewhere. Stop and listen, though, and nearly every place turns out to have its own timbre.

We knew one particularly interesting space under a bridge over the Yenisei. Cars passed overhead, creating an uneven but fairly steady pattern of thuds and rumbling. Beneath the bridge there was a reverberation of its

own: sound bounced, lingered, changed according to where it came from and how much time had passed. Nobody had built a recording studio there. The space didn't need studio equipment to become part of a recording.

Before I joined Itsari, the others made almost an entire album there called *Funny Pictures*. It belonged to a very different world from the ordinary verse-and-chorus song. Mitka played flute; there was percussion; Vitaly read his poems and occasionally tried to sing. His vocal abilities weren't those you'd expect from someone with academic musical training. Picking a note out of thin air and

accurately following intervals from it was hard for him. But he had an excellent feel for where his voice needed to enter the overall texture, and what it could change by entering.

I thought about that difference for a long time. Judge a musician by a single measure, such as pitch accuracy, and you may completely miss another gift. Someone may not sing reliably in tune, yet have an exquisite sense of rhythm, density, and timing. Vitaly would later demonstrate this on the synthesizers. While somebody else carefully searches for the right notes, he might find a particular noise or pulse that

suddenly gives the piece a face of its own.

You can't call the sound of cars crossing a bridge musical in the usual sense, either. There is no coordinated key, no promise of a regular meter. Yet if you listen, rhythm is there. Not a rhythm that belongs entirely to a drummer, but one that changes continually. The random intervals between passing cars remind you that time runs on whether or not we want to divide it into measures. A musician can ignore that outside world, or try playing along with it.

Later, when I wrote music for computer games, I needed that ability to find musical material in

the sounds around me again. Drops of water in a cave, the noise of a space, the short reflection that repeats a strike. In a way I'd first heard it all in Krasnoyarsk. We didn't discuss principles of sound design then. We simply liked finding places where things sounded strange.

Alongside this there was perfectly ordinary youth. We'd gather at somebody's place, see who had how much money, buy something to eat. Dumplings, for example, solved lunch very nicely. Then we'd switch on the tape recorder and play. Or not play. There was hardly a line between a “proper” rehearsal and spending time with friends. We didn't expect to

produce a finished piece every time. Sometimes music happened because we wanted to be together and instruments happened to be close at hand.

When I listen to those old recordings today, the everyday life behind them almost seems audible. I know the improvisation wasn't produced by some abstract collective but by a handful of young men, each with his habits, personality, and way of hearing. That's why I don't want their story reduced to dates, names, and equipment. Without the courtyards, conversations, food, and aimless walks, it would be incomplete. The sounds came out of a life in which there was

still room for doing things without a purpose.

And purposelessness sometimes takes you somewhere you could never deliberately arrive. You go walking without looking for a composition and find an interesting echo. Sit down to rehearse a song and suddenly discover an instrumental piece of its own. Or decide to end on a long note and find a new piece growing from it. During those years we were gradually learning not to stop such things from happening.

Part Three. Music Without a Leader

When the Engine Left

Mitka had a remarkable talent for holding things together. Within the band we didn't treat him as a boss in any strict sense. We understood one another's interests and strengths well enough. But the outside world required somebody to make calls, negotiate, travel across town, and explain why *we*, of all people, should be given a stage. That person was Mitka.

He occupied a special place onstage, too: expressive,

unrestrained, talkative. There was something of Jim Morrison's stage manner in him, or so it seemed to me. Mitka could say something unexpected, strike up a conversation with anyone, make contact without hesitation. For someone like me, who often didn't even want to disturb a musician after a concert I'd enjoyed, it was almost a separate art form.

Then Mitka enrolled to study film directing and moved to St. Petersburg. We were happy for him. The move itself wasn't entirely out of the blue: earlier, four of us, Mitka, Valka, Zhenya, and I, had made a trial trip there and lived for a while in a rented

apartment opposite a bakery production facility downstairs. I was around twenty; the precise age has faded. But the feeling hasn't. It was my first real gulp of freedom, as though the city were not just somewhere around me but proof that a different life was possible.

After Mitka left for good, the band seemed to lose its momentum. For about six months we did almost nothing. Not because we were overcome with grief or had made some principled decision to stop playing. We simply discovered how much depended on his habit of organizing everything. Before, a phone call could arrive: there's

a concert, we need to go, time to get ready. Now each of us had to decide for himself why he should even pick up an instrument today.

It still amazes me how much collective creativity depends on people who don't seem to determine a single note. You can know your parts perfectly, own good instruments, love music passionately. But if nobody calls, arranges a venue, or suggests getting together, nothing happens. Organization is part of the ensemble too. It's just that its sound can't be recorded on a tape machine.

Much of our old repertoire had been built around Mitka's songs.

He brought the harmonic foundation, sometimes just two or three chords, the words, and a particular character. We decorated that structure, each adding something of our own. Those songs could be very good. I still enjoy listening to some of the Itsari recordings. But there was a framework: here is a song, here is its author, and our job is to perform it without losing what makes it recognizable.

Mitka's departure left an empty space without boundaries already marked out. At first we didn't know what to do with it. Only later did we discover that having no leader needn't be a deficiency. It could be a feature of

a new way of playing. Nobody brings the complete structure. Each person brings his hearing and his willingness to answer somebody else.

I brought short phrases invented on bass, or first on guitar and then adapted for bass. Sometimes a possible complete composition already existed in my head. But I deliberately didn't describe all of it. If Valka heard only the impulse, his next move might surprise even me. Then I, in turn, would have to find a new reply. A chain would emerge that had never existed in either of our heads separately.

We thought a lot about what leadership means in music.

Formally, we decided we wouldn't have any. That doesn't mean everyone must play equally actively at every moment. Sometimes one musician takes the initiative for several minutes. Another falls into the background, a third maintains the pulse. Then the roles change. But nobody owns the final say over where the music is headed. That was the fascinating part.

In that situation, hearing another person is harder than playing a prepared part. You must be willing to abandon your own decision even if it seemed perfect a minute ago. You must stay out of someone's way while he's feeling toward a theme. Leave a

pause when the space is already full. Hold the rhythm when someone has lost his footing, and not be afraid to lose your own if the others have found a new direction.

We called the group **Hysteresis and Corpuscles** (*Гистерезис и Корпускулы*). Vitaly, also known as Chaos, came up with the name. He studied mathematics and physics and liked the vocabulary. Hysteresis: a system carrying a memory of its previous states. Corpuscles: tiny particles. At the time I saw no prophecy in it. Now it's funny to look back along the winding line from that name to John Quark, whom I invented

much later, to a raccoon, and to an entire Factory of Absurdities.

But we weren't building a future mythology then. We were occupied with what might happen if we switched on the tape recorder and tried again. That brief organizational vacuum turned into the beginning of the most unusual musical experience of my life.

The Train We All Invented

With some compositions, it isn't honest to say, “I wrote this, and somebody else wrote that.” You can point to the person who brought the first seed or remember who discovered the

defining timbre. But between the first phrase and the finished piece there are so many answers to one another that authorship no longer fits neatly onto a line with one name.

Parovoz, or *The Steam Train*, began with an idea of mine. I played it as chords on bass. It had a particular rhythm, a sense of movement I wanted to develop. As usual, Valka heard not only what I'd played but what might answer it. He joined in on guitar and started changing the space. Gradually the music took on the character of a journey: movement, a kind of stop, a return to the route, renewed movement, and finally an arrival.

Later I could distinguish four dramatic sections in *Parovoz*, although formally it had grown from just a few simple elements.

Vitaly joined in once the piece had an image. We'd called it *The Steam Train*, and suddenly he knew where to begin his search. Somehow he coaxed a sound out of the synthesizer that resembled a working, moving train. Not mere decoration over our parts, but an independent rhythmic engine. It gave everyone else something to follow.

That's a good example of why I consider him a full coauthor, regardless of the quirks of his singing ear. We can talk about melodies, chords, precision of

intervals. But without his discovery, *Parovoz* would have been entirely different music. Sometimes one rhythmic image changes the structure of a piece more profoundly than a dozen carefully chosen chords.

I liked hearing the synthesizer stop sounding like a set of keys and turn into something with machinery, weight, and motion. It returned to an old idea: sound can do more than depict movement; it can organize movement. When you start playing against such a pulse, your hands respond before you think about meter or harmony. After a while nobody needs to explain

when to enter. Everyone can hear the train starting to move.

Vitaly's synthesizer was rather temperamental. Turn a knob slightly and the speed or pitch might drift. In music built around exact metronomic repetition, that could be a problem. In our improvisations it sometimes generated a new direction. But we still needed a rhythmic reference point. I often ended up being the person who held the general tempo while letting the others wander into freer territory.

Bass is particularly interesting here. The audience tends to notice the guitar solo or the singer first. Bass seems obvious,

almost too necessary to deserve attention. Yet remove it and much of the sound loses its physical depth. That isn't always just about low frequencies. The bass determines the harmonic foundation, the direction of rhythmic motion, the background against which a higher melody is heard. In a small ensemble, a bassist has to do several jobs at once.

I had no ambition to become a conductor. But in some pieces that is effectively what I had to be: establish the pulse, show where to begin, support a transition, notice when someone is about to enter. Vitaly's rhythm helped in *Parovoz*. Still, as the

themes developed, we returned to listening to one another without a written plan. The train might go a little faster, hesitate, make a strange stop. That was fine.

Once the composition took shape, we discovered that it was quite long. Before, a song might end after two or three minutes. Now a single theme might need longer than that just to reveal itself. We didn't decide on a duration beforehand. We played until it became clear that an idea had run its course or it was time to move on.

The funny thing is that the next thing after *Parovoz* wasn't a stop at all. It was another composition,

born from a purely technical problem. Vitaly had to reset his synthesizers for the next piece. Without planning to write anything new, we found a way of making the interval itself part of the music.

Interlude: How Not to Stop

Valka loved long final notes. Where another guitarist might play the last chord and release the strings, Valka let the sound hang. Sometimes it simply faded beautifully into the air. Sometimes something entirely different began. I listened to the note stretching out and cautiously tried answering it on bass. Valka answered back. A

phrase formed, followed by another. By the time the others had realized the previous piece was over, we were already playing the next one.

That's how *Interlude* appeared at a rehearsal. We'd finished *Parovoz*, and Vitaly needed to reconfigure his synthesizers for *Station Mir*. The effect settings couldn't be changed instantly. It took a minute or two, and we didn't want to interrupt the living movement. Valka and I simply kept playing, treating the prolonged last note as a starting point.

The best thing about this solution was that it required no special introduction. The listener didn't

hear the customary announcement: the next number will begin after a short break. There was no break. The space between the pieces became musical in its own right. And after Vitaly finished setting up, he didn't need to crash back in. He could gradually introduce a new rhythm and new timbres into what we were playing, those short impulses from which *Station Mir* would emerge.

If someone had asked us to transcribe *Interlude* into notation, we could probably have reconstructed particular motifs. But its meaning wasn't in a fixed order of notes. Its meaning was that we found a way to remain

together even while one of us was busy preparing the next sound rather than playing. That preparation wasn't hidden backstage. It became part of the piece's development.

I like to think of this music as a conversation that continues when one participant goes off to fetch some water. When he returns, he can understand exactly where to rejoin. The others don't have to fall silent in his absence. They keep the thought moving and leave room for him to return. An ensemble becomes more than the sum of the instruments sounding at the same time.

Station Mir itself had appeared earlier, when Valka and I first recorded a duo improvisation on a reel-to-reel tape machine. I had expected something almost punk-like, rhythmic and exuberant. In my head I was even adding imaginary drums. We played it once, and something completely different came out. Afterwards we sat for a long time trying to understand what had grown from the original idea.

The later group version developed its own pattern of entries. Vitaly could begin with a quiet pulse on the synthesizer, then speed it up or change it in response to our signals. I'd pick up the low rhythmic line and

gradually move into the musical material. Valka answered on guitar. Kirill might enter with flute, harmonica, or a vocal effect when he felt that the overall space had opened a place for him.

The name *Station Mir* carried several meanings. There was the real orbital station Mir, a symbol of international human presence in space. There was the space of my childhood: Zodiac, synthesizer records, and strange science-fiction covers. There was also the slang in which people experimenting with mind-altering substances were called *cosmonauts*. All of it mingled together, but I didn't

want to turn the music into an illustration of only one meaning.

Ultimately we had a coherent sequence of three pieces. *The Steam Train* set out somewhere. *Interlude* allowed the movement to change shape. *Station Mir* opened another scale of space. I've always liked the fact that this transition came from the practical need to change a synthesizer's settings. In a conventional story of a band's achievements, you'd probably omit that minor detail. For me it contains the essence of our improvisations: an unforeseen circumstance becomes material if you don't automatically regard it as an obstacle.

Two Chairs and a Standing Ovation

With the longer pieces, not only our music changed but our appearance onstage. I was used to composing complex parts while sitting. When both hands work on the fingerboard at once, holding a bass line, playing intervals, moving between slap, chords, and muted percussion, the body looks for a stable position. I couldn't stand with a heavy instrument, move and jump and do all the things a rock musician is expected to do while preserving that technique.

Somebody might have called it a lack of skill. I knew perfectly well

that other bassists could do similar things standing up. But why turn a performance into a demonstration of a way of playing that was uncomfortable for me? I needed the sound. I said I would play sitting down. Valka agreed and decided he'd like a chair too. Thus our modest technical requirement was born: the stage had to have two chairs.

Vitaly stood behind his synthesizers. Kirill usually stood too, with his flute, harmonica, and microphone. Sometimes he did nothing for a long time because the music didn't need him yet. That was perfectly normal. True improvisation doesn't oblige everybody to prove

their presence every second. Sometimes knowing when *not* to play is at least as valuable as knowing how to make a beautiful entrance.

We played at various venues around Krasnoyarsk. I remember an outdoor performance near the Lenin Museum during the Krasnoyarsk Biennale. Playing this kind of music outside isn't easy: the air handles sound differently, and open space doesn't hold reflections like a room. But bringing our instrumental music into the world of familiar rock shows created a remarkable contrast.

As I remember it, the Krasnoyarsk scene revolved

mainly around heavy metal, punk, and more traditional rock. I'm not saying nobody in the city experimented. I remember, for instance, a wonderful singer I once heard at a concert. He played keyboards beautifully, sang his own songs, and performed something by Freddie Mercury. I wanted to go up and say how much I'd enjoyed it. I couldn't bring myself to. I still understand why: musicians are gathering themselves before a show and recovering afterwards. You don't always want to interrupt them with your admiration.

The audience response at our own concerts was therefore

especially surprising. We'd come out, set down two chairs, and play long pieces without a conventional frontman or verses and choruses. People didn't always know what to make of us. But the curiosity I remember was real, not merely polite.

The most important concert for me took place at Krasnoyarsk State University. Valka arranged it. As I recall, it was a comparatively small university hall, perhaps a large lecture room. Other bands played before us. Time was limited, so we chose two numbers: *Parovoz* and *Station Mir*. Together they gave a sense of what our band had become, without trying to

squeeze an entire evening into a few minutes.

What I remember most is the intimacy of the room. There was no enormous distance between the players and the audience, no feeling that you were performing far away to a faceless mass of people. The listeners were close. They could hear every irregularity of a live performance. And you could hear whether they were listening. That mattered more to me than stage lighting or rock-show decoration. When people listen, another feedback loop forms between the stage and the hall.

We played *Parovoz*, then *Station Mir*. Each piece contained things

we could repeat and places that had to come into being anew each time. I don't remember every note of that concert. I couldn't: the notes didn't exist in a fixed score. But I remember exactly what happened after we finished.

People stood up and applauded.

They weren't relatives or a circle of friends obliged to support us whatever happened. Many were hearing us for the first time. That's why their reaction made such an impression. For the first time I saw that our strange, long, decidedly un-radio-friendly music could reach people we'd never met.

There are moments after which you stop asking whether it's worth continuing. Not because success is guaranteed, but because for once something you were trying to express has met something another person could actually hear. I think that university concert was one of those moments.

Yet events were already moving toward another turning point. Mitka had left long before; then Valka and Zhenya began preparing to move to Petersburg. We kept going while circumstances allowed. We also recorded another extraordinary thing, an entire album that never became a concert program. When

I think about it now, it seems to preserve not only our music but the texture of a time when we could still sit down and play without first discussing when everyone had to leave.

Part Four. The Shaman's Circle

One Take, One Journey

Some studio albums are assembled from countless takes. A musician records a part, does it again, fixes a note, records another instrument, adds an effect. The finished track is a version that never actually existed in that form in real time. There's nothing wrong with this. Editing and multitrack recording can produce extraordinary work. Later I would use those possibilities extensively myself. But **The Shaman's Circle** came

into being in an entirely different way.

Valka and I sat down and started playing. We switched the recorder on once, and kept playing without stopping until the music ended of its own accord. Kirill was in the room listening; in the final section he joined us with his instruments. What resulted was a continuous journey of roughly an hour, later divided into six tracks. The division makes it easier to listen to, but it shouldn't obscure the essential fact: originally there were no breaks between the sections in which we sat down to compose the next thing.

First came *Journey 1: Summer*. Then a short second journey I remember calling *Indian*. Then *Autumn*, *River*, the long *Desert*, and *Full Circle*. The album was given a fitting name: *The Shaman's Circle*. It suggests movement that doesn't require a single final destination. You return to a familiar rhythm or harmony, but every time you hear it from a different state of mind.

Why didn't we attempt to perform the album at concerts? Because the very idea seemed pointless. In theory, you could transcribe everything: exactly when an instrument entered, which harmony sounded, where

a pause appeared, how long a delay reflection lasted. But you'd then be reproducing the results without reproducing their causes. The cause of each musical phrase was the previous phrase, heard by two people at that particular moment. A score might preserve the material while robbing the performance of its essential freedom.

Sometimes I think a recording like this is better than a diary. In a diary you tell what happened after the fact. You select words and emphases, forget details, import today's understanding into yesterday's circumstances. In an improvisation, that interval doesn't exist. You cannot

retrospectively change a note already sounded, because the next one has already been born in response. The tape recorder preserves not a corrected version of memory but what actually happened, with the hesitations, surprises, and imperfections intact.

Of course, the recording itself cannot tell a future listener everything. It doesn't explain who was sitting where, why a part became quieter, or why a third person joined only at the end. That's what memories are for. But the most important thing about the course of the musical thought exists there in its original form. You need only switch on

the recording and try to hear not just a beautiful isolated phrase but what caused it to appear.

In those days I played a four-string fretted bass. It's important not to confuse it with the five-string fretless bass that Petrov made for me later, around the beginning of the Hysteresis and Corpuscles period. The surviving recordings make it clear that I was already hungry for a broader range of possibilities before I got that new instrument. I was trying to make four strings do more than people normally expected of a bass player.

I had a delay effect. It returned the notes I'd played quite quickly,

like the distinct echo of a small cave. Valka's reflections were longer and more diffuse, more like echoes bouncing between mountain slopes. The effects behaved differently and didn't merely duplicate each other. The guitar broadened the space; within it the bass maintained clearer recurring patterns. Sometimes I began playing against my own echoes, and it seemed that more than two musicians were present.

But delay never replaced playing. It added another layer of time. First you had to play something worth repeating. Then hear its reflection, relate it to your next phrase, occasionally leave an

opening so the whole thing didn't become a blur. After a while you begin taking the returning notes into account almost as though they belong to another participant, although they're your own, just slightly younger versions of you.

This kind of music requires patience. If you constantly insist on being at the front, the texture quickly loses transparency. Sometimes it's better to play a few low notes and wait for the guitar echoes to make room. Sometimes you take a chance, climb into the high register of the bass, and take the melody. Sometimes you simply lay down a rhythm so Valka knows where to

go. The entire album was built out of these small decisions, made by ear.

That's why I like to think of *The Shaman's Circle* not as six independent compositions but as a photograph of movement. A photograph normally captures a fraction of a second. Ours lasted more than an hour. We entered it young, with time still free and a host of untested ideas, and came out a little different. Some musical possibilities revealed themselves only because we'd exhausted the ones that came before.

Summer, Autumn, and the Water Between

It's easier for me to remember the first journeys not by their notes but by how they differ in character. The long *Summer* gives a listener time to get used to the way we converse. First you learn to distinguish the two lines, then discover that behind them are their reflections as well. When your ear starts recognizing which phrase is new and which is an echo returning through the delay, an apparently simple duo becomes intricate polyphony.

There is no conventional singer telling a story in words and thereby directing the listener's

attention. I had always thought of the voice as another instrument. Lyrics seemed to me, for a long time, like hints, sometimes unnecessary ones. If the music can make its own image, why spell it out? In our long pieces, I valued the freedom not to dictate exactly what feeling a person ought to experience.

The titles, of course, offered a frame: *Summer*, *Autumn*, *River*, *Desert*. They suggest a journey, a shift in seasons and landscapes, but they don't force you to hear a particular plot. One listener might imagine dry air and sunlight, another a journey from childhood; a third might picture nothing and simply follow the

harmonies. I like leaving listeners free to choose how they inhabit a piece.

The second journey is much shorter than the first. I think we called it *Indian*. I use the name cautiously. Details have mingled over the years, and I don't want to turn an approximate recollection into an established fact. But even that uncertainty fits the album. With living improvisation, a name often appears after the music and doesn't necessarily dictate its structure in advance.

Autumn and *River* followed. Each has its own density and way of breathing. What I remember most is not a predetermined

chord sequence, but the ability to change timbre and dynamics, gradually opening fresh spaces. On bass I could stay low and leave the high register to Valka. Then I might climb up and create two independent voices while the guitar took over support. Or mute everything to brief impacts in which you feel rhythm but pitch almost disappears.

That move toward percussion particularly interested me. Tap a string gently while muting it and you don't get an ordinary bass note. You get a short sound with a slight harmonic coloration. It resembles a tuned drum. You can vary not only the rhythm but the faint hint of pitch remaining

inside the impact. At such moments it feels as though I have a small percussion section of my own, even though I'm still playing one instrument.

I'd listened to a lot of music in which drums do more than produce dry clicks. In African musical traditions there are drums tuned to particular pitch relationships. The membrane's tension, humidity, temperature: all can affect their tuning. I'd seen musicians retune instruments even in the middle of a performance. That left an impression. A drum doesn't have to stand outside harmony; it can participate in it.

This opened up new tasks for the bass. In one moment it provides the foundation; in another it draws a melody; in a third it becomes an almost colorless pulse. Effects keep earlier notes from vanishing at once, so even a sharp change of technique can remain connected to what came before. The listener may still hear a musical phrase when I've already turned my hands into a rhythmic mechanism.

River seems a particularly good name for this approach. A river doesn't remain the same along its length: in some places the current is faster, in others slower; the same water flows between changing banks. I'm not claiming

we consciously illustrated a river with particular techniques. But the possibility of continuous change without losing the underlying line was exactly what drew us to our instruments.

When you listen to all the journeys as one take, another effect begins to make itself felt. Your ear remembers the previous section even after the recording has moved into the next. Musical ideas arise and leave, sometimes depositing nothing more than a way of moving. The guitar may change its manner while retaining the readiness to respond. The bass may abandon a theme and keep a certain rhythmic density. It's like a long

conversation whose subject changes naturally: you don't announce the start of a new conversation, although by the end of the evening you're talking about something quite different from where you began.

For that reason, I never considered the separate parts of *The Shaman's Circle* to be songs we had to learn and perform onstage. We weren't building a set list. We allowed an event to happen, recorded it, and kept it. There was no need to insist that it happen in precisely the same way again.

Desert: The Bass That Grew Extra Hands

Desert is the longest part of the cycle, about twenty and a half minutes. If you want to understand how I thought about bass guitar then, this recording probably offers more evidence than many explanations. I tried almost everything I'd learned: chords, intervals, melody, two-handed tapping, different attacks, delay, transitions into percussion and back again.

It's worth explaining two-handed tapping. Watching a bass player, most people see one hand pressing strings against the fingerboard while the other

plucks them. With tapping, either hand can sound notes directly by striking the strings against the fingerboard. You get several independent movements that have to coordinate without the usual division of labor.

My left hand could maintain a low bass line, sounding the notes with gentle taps. Meanwhile my right hand played intervals, sometimes striking two strings together. A particular repeating figure would appear, something you might sing as *pam-pam-pam*. Listen carefully, though, and it isn't a single line. The low notes continue to hold the foundation, the higher ones create harmonic movement, and the delay returns

what was played a moment ago, filling the gaps.

Then the technique would change. Instead of percussive tapping I might move into picking out the notes of a chord, holding the necessary pitches while sounding strings with my fingers. Sometimes the shift took place within one uninterrupted thought. The listener wouldn't necessarily notice the mechanics. They'd hear that the music had become softer, more transparent, that notes now arrived in sequence rather than together while remaining within the same harmony.

That was what interested me. Not proving that a bassist could do

something unusual, but achieving a particular sound. If I needed a chord, I found a way to play a chord. If I needed rhythm, I found it on the strings. If the music demanded a melodic answer to Valka, I could temporarily abandon the bass's usual function and step forward.

Of course, there was a cost. The technique became complicated and the movements required a stable position. I couldn't jump around onstage like some rock musicians. But that was a deliberate choice. For me, the important thing was happening inside the sound. The stage should adapt to the music, not the

music to the customary stage pose.

There is another feature of low sounds. The lower the note, the differently it fills physical space. With a capable sound system you can feel bass with your body as well as hear it. But low frequencies easily become muddy when a dense chord ignores how its tones combine. That is why a bassist must choose intervals and registers carefully. It's not limitation for limitation's sake; it's musical architecture. Where should the emptiness be? Where does the foundation belong? Where can the higher voices enter?

That was why I later asked Petrov to build me a five-string fretless bass. The lower fifth string offered extra depth. A fretless fingerboard allowed me to handle pitch differently, to move more smoothly between notes without being wholly bound to fixed positions. But when we recorded *The Shaman's Circle*, I didn't yet own that instrument. I was already searching for the possibilities the new bass would eventually expand.

Delay in *Desert* wasn't just decoration. Its short echo could return a rhythmic phrase just as I began playing another. That opens a dangerous but intriguing possibility: you can get in your

own way. Play too much, and the reflections collide and destroy the clarity. You have to learn to leave gaps not only between the real notes but between those that will return a moment later.

Valka's effect behaved differently. Its long, diffuse reflections made a background, a space in which the music could keep moving. Sometimes the guitar seemed farther from the listener while the bass stayed closer and clearer. Then Valka would begin a new melody, and the spatial relationship would change. On the recording you can hear it as a gradual shift of roles, not as an announcement that the guitarist is now taking a solo.

We didn't announce those changes or write them down in a notebook. One part gradually became rhythmic, another moved to the foreground, and a new harmonic foundation appeared. Sometimes just a few notes were enough to understand that your partner wanted to go somewhere else. At that point it no longer mattered which instrument was formally called the bass and which was supposed to take the lead.

Desert also reveals another quality of long improvisation: it isn't afraid of uneven density. An ordinary song often has to keep a listener engaged with recognizable repeats and

climaxes. For us, a long quiet passage could be just as important, a place where very little seems to happen until you begin noticing subtle changes. Stay with that moment and the next dense phrase will sound entirely different.

I'm not claiming we got everything perfect. We were experimenting; sometimes we reached dead ends, sometimes played longer than perhaps we should have. But that's the point of a live recording. Its beauty isn't that every hesitation has been cleaned away in advance. It shows people feeling out a shared path. *Desert* lasts so long because within that time we pass through

several different ways of understanding our instruments.

Full Circle and the Sound of a Broken Pencil Lead

While Valka and I traveled through our musical journeys, Kirill remained in the room. He didn't rush to occupy a place in the ensemble. He listened. I like thinking of that as a kind of participation in its own right. Sometimes the best preparation for music is to play nothing. He had time to sense the density that had developed, the returning rhythms, what Valka and I did with silence, how we answered each other.

In the final journey he picked up his flute and approached the microphone. He began to play. Later came the harmonica. The microphone was connected to a delay too, adding another layer of reflections, this time with the timbre of wind instruments. What interests me most is how naturally it happened: no announcement, no predetermined bar in which he had to enter. Kirill felt for himself when he could become part of the movement.

And it wasn't merely the last track of a long album. *Full Circle* gathered many of the possibilities we'd discovered during the preceding hour. I moved from

low bass to chords, from tapping to plucked figures, from melody to rhythm. Valka answered, moved into the background, came back with a new theme. Kirill added something we hadn't had before, while the reflections of our sound kept expanding the space.

Gradually a different sense of scale emerged. Not necessarily more notes, not necessarily greater volume. Rather, things that had existed separately now had room to meet. A rhythmic bass line beside delicate harmonic figures; guitar echoes mingling with flute; short reflections crossing longer ones. Three actual musicians made a

sound in which it wasn't easy to count how many voices were present at once.

I think the word *circle* in the album title matters for another reason, too. When musicians improvise for a long time, they don't travel strictly forward along a road written in advance. They can return to a familiar rhythm, but returning doesn't undo the time they've lived through. Something that sounded light and tentative at the beginning may carry a different weight at the end. Even the same note isn't quite the same after an hour of music has preceded it.

But the most remarkable thing about the last journey is how it

ends. Valka began moving his hand over the guitar strings, varying the pressure. A noise developed, growing denser and denser. It wasn't a conventional final chord or a beautiful fade-out. The musical lines seemed to lose their edges and turn into one expanding mass of sound.

For a long time I tried to describe that moment, until one day I found the right image. Imagine a clean sheet of paper and an ordinary pencil. You begin in the center, making circular movements. At first the marks are light. Then new lines cross the old ones. The center darkens, graphite accumulates. Your hand

gradually widens its movement and the shaded area spreads across the page. Meanwhile the middle keeps growing denser because the pencil passes through it again and again.

That's what happens at the end of *Full Circle*. Two movements take place at once. The center grows denser; the drawing expands outward. The sound seems to grow both deeper and wider. It becomes less important which note belongs to the bass, which is a guitar reflection, which tint comes from a wind instrument. Everything contributes to the build.

Then the pencil lead breaks.

Not because the composer wrote “sudden silence” in the score. The movement simply reaches its limit and stops. At once. And silence becomes the final sound of the work, although technically you cannot play silence with your fingers on strings.

That's the full stop at the end of *The Shaman's Circle*. I like that it can be described almost physically, through a piece of graphite and a sheet of paper. In another conversation we might explain it in terms of spectral density or a curve of dynamics. But the image of the broken pencil lead captures more precisely what I feel when I return to the recording.

After the ending, an extraordinary fact remains. There was no second take. We didn't start again with *Summer* to see if we could do better. We didn't decide to rerecord *Desert* because somewhere we'd wanted to play differently. The event existed exactly once. So when I play the album today, I hear not only the music but a moment of our lives that cannot be repeated.

And yet the recording repeats each time I press Play. That's its quiet paradox. Music born as an unrepeatable chain of accidents can sound again and again. The listener knows where it will lead. The musicians inside the recording still don't. Every time,

they are still making those decisions for the first time. The tape recorder preserved their not knowing.

Part Five. When Life Changes, Not the Music

The Petersburg We'd Been Planning to Reach

We first visited St. Petersburg before any of us moved there for good. There were four of us: Mitka, Valka, Zhenya, and me. We rented an apartment overlooking a place that made bread and pastries. I remember it not for its address or floor number or architectural features, but for the feeling that you could wake up in an unfamiliar city and not be

obliged to return immediately to the life you knew.

I was around twenty, perhaps a little older or younger. I'm not going to reconstruct my age with calendar precision now. The important thing is that it was one of my first real tastes of freedom. Before that you could fantasize about another city all you wanted. Now it was beneath your feet: real streets, a real apartment, an ordinary day you could spend however you liked. The pastries being made downstairs weren't a symbol; they were perfectly material pastries. That made the feeling of change stronger, not weaker.

Even before the trip we lived in a fairly free musical time. We could rehearse for hours, argue over a melody, get together without warning, play, then part without a finished piece. Still, each of us had a Krasnoyarsk life. Petersburg let us imagine that the familiar arrangement of circumstances could be changed. Perhaps the music would remain and only our address would change. Perhaps everything else would follow.

Eventually that is what happened, though not necessarily in the way we'd imagined.

Mitka went to study film directing. He had a direction to follow and a reason to move. He'd

always been good at getting excited about a new undertaking and then making circumstances adapt to it somehow. In our music he was the one who found gigs, got to know organizers, made calls, traveled around, negotiated. Now his energy was heading somewhere else.

After he left, we simply stopped rehearsing for a while. Nobody ceremonially disbanded the old band. There was no dramatic announcement about artistic differences. It just became much harder to arrange the next meeting when the usual organizer was no longer calling to tell everyone where to be and at what time.

Then Hysteresis and Corpuscles happened, and we discovered something unexpected: losing the leader opened the door to music that didn't need a leader at all. But that discovery couldn't cancel everyday life. Valka and Zhenya left for Petersburg too. Valka went to study photography as an art; Zhenya, fashion design. I remained in Krasnoyarsk with Vitaly, sometimes with Kirill around. For a while there was still a sense that the band existed even as its musicians moved to different cities. But music depends enormously on people being physically present.

You can't conduct a real rehearsal through memories of one. You

can remember how your friend holds a guitar, what sound he likes to leave at the end of a phrase, how he responds to your unexpected chord. But you cannot hear what he'll play tomorrow if tomorrow he's thousands of kilometers away. And it was precisely that uncertainty that had been the center of our work.

Later I moved too. Now, you might think, we were all in the same city again. We could go on. But it turned out that you cannot pack your old life in boxes with the musical instruments. A life consists not only of people, but of the time they have available.

It wasn't Petersburg's fault. It wasn't anyone's fault. We were simply growing up.

Ptitsa 107: A Reunion After a Long Journey

Our last shared project was called **Ptitsa 107** (*Bird 107*). It lasted only a short time, roughly 2001 to 2002. By then I owned the five-string fretless bass Petrov had built for me. Valka played guitar. Mitka sang, played harmonica, invented noises and all kinds of extra sounds that don't fit neatly into a standard list of “vocals, guitar, bass.”

We tried to get together as a trio once more and make music.

There was continuity, but the circumstances were entirely different. Mitka was studying, Valka was studying, I was working. The city demanded each of us separately. There had been a time when we could meet for the whole day without knowing when it would end. Now a meeting had to fit between other events. The more important those events became, the harder it was to pretend that time was still unlimited.

Yet we hadn't forgotten how to play with one another.

There are moments on the surviving recordings when you can hear us laughing. Not a carefully planned artistic effect

or an attempt to record a comedy number. Just the ordinary laughter of people who understand perfectly that something unexpected has happened. Those are among the moments I treasure most. They tell me more about a band than a catalogue of what each member could do technically.

Musicians are often described by their instruments. One can play a particular passage, another uses a rare effect, a third has a remarkable vocal range. All of that can be measured, recorded, compared. Far harder to describe is how people anticipate each other in the instant before anything has been decided. Over

the years Valka and I had answered one another's notes countless times before we'd even managed to explain what interested us in them. With Mitka, the interaction had its own character. His voice and his way of inhabiting a composition changed the atmosphere immediately.

When the three of us came together again, it still worked. But the time around the sounding music was different. Perhaps that's why the late improvisations contain such a vivid meeting with the past. Not that we deliberately tried to reproduce our younger selves. Rather, we met as people who still shared a musical

language but no longer had the chance to speak it every day.

The project left an album. The recordings include *I'm a Thief* and *Expressionism*. Their titles, sounds, and individual decisions deserve a calm, careful study alongside the original files. I don't want to assign every piece a concept after the fact. What's more important to me is simply that we did get together again, play, and record. The connection hadn't vanished the moment our address changed.

It would be too easy to end this chapter with “Childhood was over, and so was the music.” The music didn't end. Some ways of making it simply require an

almost impossible coincidence of circumstances. You have to know how to play, yes. But on a particular day people must also want to be together, find the time, arrive, open their instrument cases, and leave everything else outside the door.

Sometimes that happens.

Sometimes all that remains is a recording.

Moda and Someone Else's Harmony

After Ptitsa 107 I tried playing with other people a few more times. One of those experiences involved Vitaly Kudinov, a colleague from work who had a

band called **Moda**. Vitaly loved Muse. He was a good pianist with a strong voice, and he wrote songs with complex harmony. This was not at all the kind of music we'd been making on our free journeys through Krasnoyarsk.

When he invited me, I warned him about something quite significant. I no longer knew how to sit with a bass and calmly repeat the same root note four times, waiting for the next chord. Not because I considered that style wrong. Sometimes it's exactly what a piece needs, and a good bassist ought to know when to leave space for someone else. But if I join a project as a

musician, I want to invent my own line. And that line will inevitably change the music.

Vitaly agreed.

I went to a rehearsal and recorded what they were playing: guitars, piano, vocals. Then I took the recording home. For someone accustomed to improvisation, this reversed the usual sequence. Before, I'd bring Valka a little musical impulse and we'd find out together what it could become. Here the composition already existed, with its own logic, transitions, and harmonic peculiarities. I had to study it first.

It was almost impossible to work out bass parts like that on the spot. You could catch the general mood by ear, find a series of low foundational notes, and play something vaguely suitable. But “vaguely suitable” didn't interest me. I wanted to know how the whole structure held together, where it could accept an additional voice, and where a new part would upset a balance that had already been found.

I opened Logic Pro and began working with the recording on the computer. I'd always loved the sound of a double bass and dreamed of having a real one. Here I used a sampled upright bass. It couldn't replace a wooden

acoustic body vibrating in a room, but it gave me the timbre I imagined for that music.

At first this might seem the opposite of everything I loved about bass guitar. In an improvisation I built a line with my hands, could change a note in a second and immediately hear my partner answer. Now I had to listen to a finished recording, work out the structure, and place my own sounds carefully. But there was freedom here as well. You come to understand someone else's musical system well enough to propose something new inside it without destroying what works.

I love the moment when an additional instrument suddenly

gives someone else's song greater depth. Not because that instrument becomes louder or more noticeable. Sometimes the best part draws almost no attention to itself. It's simply that, after it enters, the original harmony starts sounding different, and the listener can't immediately say why.

My time with Moda was brief. Work and ordinary obligations gradually claimed everyone's time. There was no grand finale. But that small experience showed me that an improviser's ear can also be useful in a carefully structured arrangement. You only need the other musicians to agree that the music is allowed to

change in the course of working on it.

A Duo That Required Several Musicians in One

Around the same time another person from Starsoft approached me. He wrote songs for guitar and suggested that we play together. I found his material unusual and interesting. But the lineup was as small as it could be: him with a guitar and a voice, me with a bass. Nobody else.

I gave him much the same warning I'd given Vitaly. If he wanted the bass to follow quietly alongside his guitar, he'd do better to invite somebody else.

My way of playing would inevitably alter the original structure of the songs. He agreed, and we started experimenting.

For me this was an exercise less in virtuosity than in musical economy. When Valka, Vitaly, and Kirill were around, we could each fill a different range. Guitar echoes stretched far into space. A synthesizer created a sustained atmosphere or a mechanical pulse. The flute passed over the overall texture, sometimes returning through the delay attached to its microphone. My job was to listen for empty spaces and decide whether they needed filling.

Here, the empty spaces were everywhere.

The voice occupied the foreground. The guitar supplied chords. The bass had to carry the low frequencies, create additional harmony, and occasionally answer the vocal melody, all at once. I returned to tapping, chords, intervals, and the movement between rhythm and solo. Not to display technique, but because otherwise the duo would have sounded much thinner than I wanted.

In a sense I faced the problem that had interested me since childhood: hear several independent musical lines and understand what's missing from

the whole. Only now, instead of an entire orchestra, there were two people. And instead of asking, “Who is falling out of time?” I asked, “Which part of the musical space can I take responsibility for without getting in my partner's way?”

We recorded a few songs. Then that chapter ended too.

If you judge a musical life only by the dates when bands formed and broke up, short collaborations like these look minor. For me they're interesting precisely because each posed a different question. In one band you search for freedom among many players. In another you enter a harmony somebody else

has already composed. In a third you try to replace several missing musicians with one instrument. The instrument may stay the same, but the musical task changes each time.

Still, after these experiences I looked for a band less and less often.

Not because I stopped loving music.

Perhaps it was simply beginning to serve another purpose.

Part Six. The Sound of Someone Else's Imagination

An Experiment That Required No Humming

Of all my later musical activities, writing for computer games stands apart as an experiment. I wasn't interested merely in composing a soundtrack. I wanted to find out whether I could do something much stranger: hear another person's sensations described in words, then turn them into music so that the person recognized precisely what they'd wanted to feel.

The opportunity came about for a practical reason. A former Starsoft colleague had started his own business making computer games. One day he complained that composers charged far too much. I said I'd be happy to try for free. He could tell me what he wanted; I'd write some music; then we'd see whether it worked. If it did, we could discuss the next step.

At the time I cared more about proving to myself that such a translation was possible than about landing a contract. Professionally, my offer probably wasn't very businesslike: unknown amount of work, unknown result, no guarantee of

payment. But I wasn't treating music as my main source of income. I had a programming job. I chose the musical problem because I wanted to solve it.

The most important part happened before I went anywhere near an instrument. I didn't ask the developer to hum an opening, choose chords, or specify a tempo. I wanted to avoid ready-made musical instructions. With those, I would merely have been reproducing another person's melodic idea. My experiment called for something else: a description of the world itself.

What does the player see? What is the cave like? What kind of

space should the game contain? What is the water like? What does this place *feel* like? Not musical terminology, but images, temperature, light, movement, scale, the density of the air, even though all of it existed only inside an imagined game environment.

I listened to his answers. Sometimes I asked follow-up questions. Then I went home and tried to construct a musical picture from those sensations.

You could easily call this illustrative composing, but that was too narrow a word for what I was doing. An illustration depicts an object. Music cannot show a stalactite or a spacecraft as directly as a picture can. But it

can suggest scale, movement, anticipation, unease, or weightlessness. It can make a small screen feel spacious. It can make the player imagine the dampness of a cave before they notice the drops of water in the picture.

What interested me was the transition between two languages. One person talks about a place using everyday words. Another builds from sounds not a literal description, but a state in which the first person recognizes his own idea.

And the remarkable thing was that **I got it right every time**. I wasn't guessing a specific melody someone had hummed to me

beforehand. I was finding a sound in which my listener recognized the feeling he wanted.

As long as I worked directly with the director who had founded the project, he recognized that feeling in what I brought him. I didn't need to guess a melody because no melody existed in his mind in advance. He described a world; I looked for a way to make it audible. It felt as though we were truly communicating in one language, although we used entirely different forms of expression.

That mattered more to me than a compliment about the composition. I wasn't looking to be told that I played guitar well. I

wanted to know whether a bridge could be built between an image and music at all. And it could.

Acid, Water, Cave, Space

I remember one Breakout-style game particularly well. You controlled a ball and knocked out rows of bricks. But the game had several themed levels and its own introductory menu. Each part needed a different musical atmosphere. Not one endlessly repeated background tune, but several worlds inside what was, after all, a fairly simple game mechanic.

There were four levels: acid, water, caves, and space.

I listened to the descriptions and tried to understand more than how the levels differed visually. I wanted to know how they were supposed to *feel*. An acid environment doesn't have to sound chemically acidic; you can't hear a chemical in the form of a musical genre. You need to find a convention the listener will recognize as belonging to a particular world. That's a problem not of chemistry but of association and sound design.

For the water level I used an acoustic guitar. By itself its sound is dry, woody, and fairly definite. You can hear exactly when a string is touched, when a note begins, how it decays. I wanted to

disturb that certainty and make it waver, float a little. In Logic Pro I added a flanger. After processing, the familiar instrument began behaving differently. Its tone acquired movement, as though it were passing through a medium that kept changing its shape.

I wasn't trying to imitate splashing literally. I could have inserted the sound of water and left it at that. But then I'd have had a sound effect explaining the picture, not a musical atmosphere. I wanted the melody and timbre themselves to carry the sensation of water. The acoustic guitar proved unexpectedly well suited to that.

The cave presented a different problem. I wanted you to feel dampness. Not just a large void with long reverberation, but cold, wet stone, drops falling to the floor, reflections returning from the walls. I had a Sony Music sound library and found a recording of drops falling inside a cave. It wasn't a generic computer-generated *ping* or *plop*. You could hear the space in which each drop landed.

Underneath, I added a simple drum pattern and a bass melody. The result had something of a jazz character. I wasn't troubled by the fact that jazz isn't officially associated with caves. Who cares which genre supposedly belongs

where? What matters is the combined result. The bass gave the music movement, the drums held its shape, and the drops and reflections made the environment. Put everything together and even to me the dampness felt almost tangible against the skin.

Perhaps my trombone lessons and early love of jazz helped here. I knew how much an impression depends not merely on pitch but on attack, duration, and dynamics. In cave music, the brief impact of a drop can matter more than another beautiful chord. It explains the space not in words but in the time it takes an echo to return.

For space, I remembered Zodiac again.

I'd loved those records since early childhood. Not only the music but the covers captivated me: fantastic images, cosmic symbols, the sense of a vast space in which human beings were only beginning to find their place. I especially loved the bass. Together with the synthesizers, it created a solid foundation for music that seemed technical and utterly magical at the same time.

I went back through several albums, as many as I could find and had time for. I listened not for a particular effect to copy but for the principles that make a piece feel cosmic. Why does a

certain harmony suggest forward motion? Why does one synthesizer timbre seem boundless while another transports you straight back into a little room? How can a bass make fantastical music feel grounded without destroying its sense of flight?

Then I wrote my own piece, energetic and unmistakably space-minded. I wasn't trying to make a Zodiac copy. I wanted to find the same kind of sensation through my own means. To my ears, it turned out exactly right for the game.

The menu needed music as well. There the player isn't yet in the water, the cave, or space. They're

only getting ready to choose a path. The opening theme has to create anticipation without revealing everything in advance. It's a different kind of task. A player might spend seconds in a menu or linger there for minutes. So you have to consider repetition: how will the music live if someone leaves it playing without doing anything?

Gradually I discovered the special demands computer games make of composers. Game music doesn't always advance the way a conventional song does. A player may linger on one level, return to the same cave, die, and start again. A composition has to survive that kind of treatment

without breaking the atmosphere.

But those technical requirements were not the essence of my experiment. Above all, I wanted to know whether I could hear someone else's imagination.

And while I had one person to talk to, the answer remained yes.

When a Feeling Acquired Too Many Owners

In time I wrote music for several games, three or four, I think. After the first pieces I'd done for free, the developer even began paying me. It remains the only period in which music earned me money. I didn't try to build a

grand composing career out of it, and I had no intention of doing so.

The last project was the most difficult, but not for musical reasons.

As long as I worked directly with the director, everything went smoothly. He described the sensation he wanted. I listened, wrote, and presented the result. He liked it. It kept working that way until responsibility for approving the music was handed over to the team.

Instead of one person who could describe a coherent image of the game, there were now individual staff members, mostly

programmers, each with separate comments. One didn't like something. Another wanted a certain sound added. A third proposed changing a passage. None of those reactions is unreasonable in itself. People are entitled to hear music differently. But turn those individual reactions into a workflow and you have a completely different task.

Before, I had been translating one coherent sensation into music. Now I was asked to assemble music from many individual preferences that weren't always connected to one another. Every new suggestion had an author, but I could no longer sense any

shared responsibility for the artistic result.

That exhausted me far more than difficult harmony or unfamiliar technique. When you know the atmosphere you're looking for, you can rewrite a part as many times as necessary: change the timbre, the chords, the instrument, until recognition appears. But when requirements continually dissolve into little complaints of “I don't like this bit” and “add something here,” the clear objective against which you could judge the work disappears.

What made it particularly strange was that I still understood the original artistic tasks. The

experiment hadn't failed. I could still go home with someone else's description of a cave or outer space and make music in which that person recognized the feeling he wanted. What didn't work was living in a system where, afterwards, every participant in a discussion could reopen the question of what the music should be.

I had worked as a programmer for years myself, so I understood perfectly that developers have the right to influence the product. But a professional role doesn't automatically make someone a musical director. Nor does a group of people acquire one shared artistic ear merely by

belonging to the same project. It was like that school concert: you can gather several people with instruments in one room and still not have an orchestra. You can gather several opinions about sound and still not have one unified feeling.

That was my last job writing music for computer games. I didn't stop because I'd lost the ability to capture the intended sensation. I simply didn't want to work in a process where the artistic reference point was found and then dissolved into a multitude of unrelated edits.

Not because I stopped liking music for games, and not because I'd suddenly discovered that I had

no talent. I realized I didn't want to work in that mode. A creative problem ought to be difficult because the creative work is difficult, not because of an endless process of reconciling incompatible requests.

I had proved the one thing I wanted to prove: another person's feeling, described in words, could be translated into music in a way they would recognize.

My experiment needed nothing more.

From an Unwanted Hint to Another Dimension

When I first listened to rock, what interested me most was what the musicians were doing. One line belonged to the bass player, another to the guitarist, the drums pushed the whole pattern forward, and the voice entered as an instrument with a range and timbre of its own. I could follow each part separately, then gather them together again. Sometimes I didn't even need to close my eyes; shifting my attention was enough.

For a long time my relationship with lyrics was complicated. A text felt like an imposed explanation of something music

could express perfectly well on its own. It's not that I disliked singers. I listened to Vysotsky with real pleasure, for example. But most of the time I wanted to hear the composition, not receive instructions for which pictures I was supposed to imagine.

Later I realized that many people enter a song from the opposite direction. They remember the words first, find their own story in them, start singing along. Only later, sometimes years later, do they suddenly hear that another life has been unfolding behind the familiar voice all along: the bass wasn't merely repeating chords, the guitar was answering the melody, the drummer left

silence exactly where it was needed.

For me the path ran the other way. I heard the orchestra first and only later began listening carefully to what was actually being sung. And it turned out that a good lyric doesn't have to close down the imagination. It can open another space, with its own images, rhythms, and unexpected turns.

My childhood joke with the little fir tree and *The Sacred War* suddenly took on new meaning. I already knew from experience that the same words set to different music could change not just the mood but even the protagonist of a story. Before,

that had seemed a funny, slightly embarrassing accident. Now I saw it as one way in which musical and poetic languages interact.

It's especially interesting when they don't agree. A melody may promise lightness while the words tell of loss. Or the reverse: the voice may sound sad while the story in the text is full of hope. One need not illustrate the other. Sometimes their mismatch produces a meaning that neither music nor words could have created alone.

When I began listening more attentively to lyrics, my love of instrumental music didn't go anywhere. I can still sit at a

symphony concert and search with my eyes for the bassoon I've just heard inside the orchestra. It's simply that now, when a work includes a poet and a singer, I can hear another participant in the conversation.

I like the fact that participation is optional. You can stay with rhythm, timbre, and harmony. Or you can follow the words and discover a second story that has been sounding beside them all along.

Part Seven. Music Still Waiting for a Voice

Compass

Writing music for Eva felt quite different.

For games I had tried to turn descriptions of someone else's imaginary space into a musical sensation. Here everything began with words that already existed. Eva sent me a poem. I wanted it to become a song. Not just any song that happened to fit the text, but one in which she might actually enjoy hearing her own voice.

I knew what kind of music she liked: Japanese rock, including music associated with anime. It wasn't my native musical language. Of course I'd listened to a huge variety of music over the years. But recognizing the familiar marks of a genre is one thing; writing a new piece that feels natural inside it is quite another.

So I began by listening.

I walked the dogs and listened to Japanese bands one after another. I wasn't trying to memorize a fragment of somebody else's guitar solo to use later. I was more interested in the underlying grammar: how a song is built, when the texture

becomes denser, how the melody is supported, how the chords change, why certain progressions sound effortless even when the harmony inside them is rather complex.

That's how I usually learn music. “It sounds beautiful” rarely satisfies me as an answer. I want to know what creates that impression. The same melody can sound completely different depending on the instruments, the dynamics, the overall tempo, sometimes even one bass note. Once you understand that, you stop choosing at random and start making deliberate decisions.

At the same time, I've always been careful not to turn

composing into an engineering calculation that leaves the living musician merely following instructions. With Hysteresis and Corpuscles, we had learned to trust surprises. I brought Valka a musical idea without revealing everything I'd already heard in my head, so as not to take away his freedom. *Compass* posed a different task, but I still wanted to respect the freedom of the person who might eventually perform it.

I built the music around Eva's words. I considered how they might lie against a melody, where the singer would need room to breathe, and where the instruments could come forward. The result had verses and

choruses. This wasn't an hour-long journey in which nobody knew the next note in advance. It was a form that could be repeated. Yet I wanted enough harmonic life inside it to prevent the composition from becoming a simple chain of two or three chords.

At some point I discovered I'd used a great many chords. They intertwined, slid gently into one another, sometimes moved in a direction hard to explain with the most familiar progressions. But the music still sounded relatively light. I saw no contradiction there. Complexity needn't announce itself to a listener as a difficult exercise. It can live

inside a piece and serve its sense of wholeness.

I've always liked the way someone can hear a beautiful, simple line without realizing how much is holding it up underneath. A bassist understands this particularly well. One unexpected bass note can completely alter the character of a chord the guitarist or pianist continues to play exactly as before. On top, the harmony seems unchanged; beneath it, the direction has shifted. That's one reason I've never accepted the idea of bass as merely a percussive foundation for the other instruments.

With *Compass*, I could use such transitions freely because I was

responsible for the whole arrangement. Nobody ordered me to play root notes on schedule. But freedom brought a different responsibility: I had to make sure the harmony didn't use up all the space intended for the future voice. The music could be interesting in its own right, but it had originally been conceived as a song.

I finished the instrumental track. You can hear where the voice is meant to enter through the shape of the composition itself. Verses repeat, choruses return. At certain points you feel quite clearly that a human being should appear here with words.

But Eva was shy about recording the vocals. We never quite brought the song to the form I'd first imagined. *Compass* remained an instrumental recording with a place reserved for a voice that isn't there yet.

I don't regard that as a failure.

There is a complete musical idea in it. In fact, it's probably one of my best compositions, certainly one of those I value most. Not only because the harmony was interesting to work on. And not because I managed to convey something of Japanese rock. For the first time, several things important to me came together: the words of a particular person, the music that person loved to

surround herself with, and my wish to write not merely a beautiful piece but a piece *for her*.

I find it fascinating how the same composer changes according to whom he's writing for. Making water music for a brick-breaking game required me to hear an imagined space. Writing *Compass* required me to hear Eva's poem, her musical tastes, and my own sense of harmony at the same time. If I'd tried to do everything in my habitual way, I'd have missed part of the task.

Still, the central lesson was the one I'd learned long ago at rehearsals with Valka: you have to listen to more than yourself. Someone else's intention has a

voice of its own, even if, for the moment, it exists only as words on paper.

Sometimes I think the title *Compass* fits not just the song but this whole story. A compass helps you find a direction. It doesn't travel the route for you or decide where you ought to go. It simply shows one important relationship with the world. The music, too, was supposed to help Eva find a direction without occupying all her space.

Maybe a voice will appear someday. Or maybe the composition will remain as it is forever. I don't want to rush it or call it incomplete simply because

I once imagined a different outcome.

Some things have the right to stop where they stopped.

The Man on Stage and the Man with a Guitar at Home

After moving to Canada, I made almost no attempt to play in bands again. Music remained with me, but I didn't set myself the task of finding local musicians immediately, arranging gigs, and starting a new group. Perhaps experience had already taught me what I wanted and what I didn't.

Once I did decide to try. There was a songwriters' meetup in

Toronto. I chose a few of my acoustic pieces, took my guitar, and went along. Nothing extraordinary, you might think: a small performance, people interested in music, a chance to show my own work. I'd already played concerts in Krasnoyarsk, performed complex improvisations, and belonged to bands with different lineups. I'd sat onstage with a heavy five-string bass, playing two-handed tapping without worrying too much what the audience thought of my methods.

But here something unexpected happened.

I got terribly nervous.

My fingers turned to wood. At home I could play these short pieces calmly. I knew where I needed strength, where my wrist should relax, where the melody could almost flow by itself. At the meetup all that suddenly vanished. Not literally, of course. I still remembered the notes and held the same instrument in my hands. But my body began doing its familiar movements against some strange resistance. A simple task turned difficult.

I made mistakes. I could hear every one clearly; the years had trained me to notice deviations quite accurately. That only made the nerves more unpleasant. The odd thing was that nothing like

this had stopped me in long improvisations, where there wasn't even a predetermined correct next note. Here, with familiar material that was technically well within my reach, playing felt harder.

Perhaps there's a pattern to that. When you play with your people, your attention is on the music happening around you. You hear the guitar and answer. You don't have time to monitor how you look from outside. Alone, when everything depends on you, you can start checking yourself endlessly, and the checking itself gets in the way.

But then I remembered Valka.

He had once played an obviously dissonant note and, instead of flinching, held it until the mistake became part of the phrase. I couldn't alter an already written acoustic piece in quite the same way. But I could do the essential thing: not stop, not announce to the audience that something terrible had just happened, and keep the music moving.

I finished two pieces.

Then came a rather funny ending. I won a prize: two tickets and a poster for a musical show connected with Elton John's songs and *Yellow Brick Road*. Naturally, Elton John himself wasn't there; another performer sang the songs. For someone who had just

survived two short performances with great difficulty, it was an unexpected postscript.

I went home with an interesting conclusion. I hadn't forgotten how to play. I hadn't lost my ear. I hadn't stopped loving music. But I no longer found the idea of making public performance the main point of my musical life particularly attractive.

So much of what I loved happened before the stage, or entirely outside it. At home, without a schedule. In headphones, listening to an unfamiliar band and trying to understand how its sound is made. On a walk, when an unexpected harmony appears in

my head. In a quiet room where I can pick up a guitar and test it with my hands.

There, music has nothing to prove.

It simply appears.

Two Hundred and Fifty Ideas

I have Voice Memos on my phone now. You can start recording with one tap. That suits me much better than the elaborate process of setting up a full studio session. When an interesting musical thought appears, I want to catch it before it leaves my fingers.

The app gives recordings default names: *My Idea 1*, *My Idea 2*, and

so on. The numbering passed two hundred some time ago and is now somewhere around two hundred and fifty.

Naturally, I'm not claiming to have two hundred and fifty finished compositions. That would be strange arithmetic. Some recordings contain only a good sequence of chords. Others are fragments of melody I never had time to develop. Sometimes material repeats. Sometimes I try something, hear that it hasn't worked, and forget to delete the file.

But even if a hundred worthwhile ideas emerge from the pile, that's an interesting archive. Even fifty would be. For me, the important

thing isn't the number but the genuine attempts to catch a particular thought behind it. Some remain attempts. Others already sound so complete that I don't want to add anything to them.

Most of the recordings are short: thirty seconds to a couple of minutes. I used to think they were only rough sketches. When I had more time, I'd bring them into Logic Pro, add bass, drums, other instruments, and make full arrangements. Then they'd become *real* compositions.

Over time I've grown less certain that they need that transformation.

Sometimes a thought is complete in forty seconds. It has a beginning, a little development, and a point beyond which any continuation would be different music. Why lengthen it artificially simply because people generally think a song ought to last several minutes? If I've managed to say what mattered in a short time, another verse won't improve it.

That's an unusual position for someone who once played *The Shaman's Circle* for more than an hour without stopping. But perhaps there is no contradiction. Then we wanted to explore where a musical thought could go if we didn't cut it short in advance. Now, sometimes, I want

to preserve the exact moment in which it appeared without making it travel an entire route.

A long improvisation and a one-minute sketch both demand trust in musical time. In the first case you trust that a theme still has somewhere to go. In the second you sense that it has already said enough. In both, it's dangerous to make duration a value in itself.

I like another quality of these phone recordings: almost nothing stands between a musical idea and preserving it. I don't need to assemble a band, arrange rental of a rehearsal room, carry a heavy bass and amplifier across town, switch on several amps,

and check microphones. I don't need to fit somebody else's schedule. I just pick up the guitar.

Of course, with that freedom I've also lost the thing that made the Krasnoyarsk improvisations unrepeatable: the living response of another person. A phone won't play an unexpected note and force me to turn it into a new theme. But sometimes I don't want that, either. Sometimes what I need isn't an ensemble, but time alone with my own hearing.

There is music in that solitude too.

Coda. While the Echo Lasts

I have a simple way of checking whether music is still inside me. I pick up a guitar, sit somewhere I won't be disturbed, and try to play something that didn't exist a minute before.

Sometimes my fingers immediately find familiar movements. I have to steer them away deliberately; otherwise I'll play not a new thing but several bars of something I invented years ago. Sometimes one unexpected interval appears. I repeat it, shift the bass note, and the entire harmony changes color slightly. I can hear that the little

movement might have somewhere to go.

I start recording on my phone.

Almost nothing in that procedure resembles our rehearsals in Krasnoyarsk. No need to pool money for dumplings, decide whose place to meet at, haul a heavy bass and an amplifier. No need to wait for Vitaly to reconfigure his synthesizers. Nobody says, “Let's try that again, just a little faster.” If the idea is interesting, it stays in the phone's memory. If it isn't, it may stay there too; I never manage to delete all the unnecessary recordings.

Yet in another sense surprisingly little has changed.

I still don't know in advance what will come out. I may have an intention, imagine the character of a piece, then hear a harmony other than the one I'd expected. Sometimes it's worse. Sometimes it makes me change the entire direction of the composition. At that moment it helps to remember Valka, who once decided not to correct a wrong note. He simply stayed with it, let the dissonance sound, and then found his way back.

I often think the most important musical lessons are difficult to retell without the actual sound. You can explain at length why it

sometimes helps to play more quietly, why one low note changes the harmony of an entire chord, and how a long echo can create space around just two instruments. But true understanding comes when you hear it happen. That's why I'm glad the old recordings survived. They preserved not only notes but the occasions on which we discovered something for the first time.

Valka's reel-to-reel recorder could capture an uninterrupted hour-long journey. Now my phone saves forty seconds. In neither case does duration tell you how valuable a musical thought is. Some pieces need

twenty minutes to finish their conversation. Others need only a few chords.

Perhaps someday I'll sort through all those *My Ideas*, select a few dozen, and assemble something resembling a solo album. Or perhaps I won't assemble anything at all. For me, the recordings already exist as small, complete encounters with sound.

And still, sometimes, as I finish another short phrase, I mentally return to the room where Valka and I recorded our improvisations. He is holding a long guitar note, as though it's been time to finish for ages, but his hand hasn't yet released the string. I listen, find an answer on

the bass. He hears it and adds another note.

And something appears that neither of us could have invented alone.

The recording is twenty-five years old now. But when I play it, it happens again.

While the echo lasts.

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Author's Edition · 0 of 10

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